P3

Jan 28, 2026 01:17 PM

SmartNote

Summary

The meeting focused on evaluating how a volunteer makes "fair" allocation decisions between potential food donation recipients using a structured survey of 45 scenarios. The participant reflected on which factors matter most, how an automated algorithm might support or miss human judgment, and how different stakeholders' views should be weighted in building a fair allocation system.

Key takeaway

Fair Donation Allocation Criteria

- **Fair donation allocation should be driven by measurable need, unmet needs, and how efficiently donations translate into client impact.**

- The participant described a fair decision as considering which organization's needs are currently unmet, how efficiently the intermediary can deliver, and how far the donation will go toward directly feeding clients.
- They emphasized quantifiable aspects like poverty rates, income levels, and food access to determine relative need and suggested that organizations could be "scored" on these dimensions.

Factors Prioritized in Scenario Decisions

- **Income level, poverty rate, and food access consistently outweighed other factors in the participant's scenario choices.**

- When explaining choices between recipient A and B, the participant repeatedly referred to higher poverty rates, lower incomes, and lower food access as reasons to favor one recipient over another.
- They reported prioritizing the relationship between area income and poverty rate, as well as clients' access to food, over other presented variables like travel time.

Role and Limits of Travel Time and Logistics

- **Travel time and some logistical burdens matter but did not significantly influence this volunteer's notion of fairness.**

- The participant acknowledged that drive time could be important for many volunteers but personally minimized its importance, citing that they already enjoy driving (e.g., also driving for Lyft).
- They noted, however, that certain delivery contexts—such as residential buildings without a front desk—could create safety concerns that might discourage volunteers from taking particular rescues.

Stakeholder Influence and Aggregating Preferences

- **Employee perspectives should carry more weight than volunteers or donors when aggregating fairness preferences for the algorithm.**

- The participant felt donors generally care more about giving than about the exact destination, so their influence on allocation decisions could be relatively lower.
- They believed both employees and volunteers should be considered, but employees of the food rescue organization should have the strongest voice, with some consideration of drive time to keep assignments reasonable for drivers.
- They anticipated potential issues in aggregating stakeholder responses because volunteers may weigh factors like drive time differently from employees.

Trust and Expectations for an Automated Allocation Algorithm

- **An algorithm can approximate fair decisions but will always lack some human emotional nuance, requiring demonstrated performance to build trust.**

- The participant believed a computer could "get close" to fair decisions but would miss emotional elements that humans incorporate into fairness judgments.
- They expressed cautious, incremental trust in automation in general, preferring to see performance and "good reviews" or satisfactory outcomes over time before fully relying on such a system.
- When asked about algorithmic "errors," they suggested that if the organization ultimately trusts the algorithm, discrepancies between human and algorithm choices may reflect the algorithm using additional factors rather than a clear-cut mistake.

Perceptions of the Survey and Real-World Fit

- **The survey's structure was seen as a realistic and useful approximation of real-world donation choices.**

- The participant felt the survey captured key factors they would consider when deciding where to donate food or time, and they found the process manageable though they recognized that making such tradeoffs is inherently difficult.
- They did not identify major missing quantitative factors but mentioned that demographic details of recipients (e.g., age groups, disabilities) were not personally important to them; they were more focused on numerical indicators of need and access.

Volunteer Motivation and Impact Perception

- **The volunteer is motivated by visible gratitude and believes donations can have especially high impact for smaller, less-connected organizations.**

- They reported feeling their time is well spent because clients are clearly appreciative and look forward to regular donations.
- They highlighted that donations to smaller organizations without many other partners may produce larger marginal benefit than the same donation to larger, well-connected organizations.

Chapters

Project background and need for automation
The speaker explains that the organization has grown significantly over the past two years, leading to demand surpassing staff capacity. They are collaborating to create an algorithm to automate the donation allocation process, which is currently handled manually by the manager, Jennifer England.
0s

Introduction to the fairness survey methodology
The researcher describes the plan to collect data from donors, volunteers, and recipients to define what fair allocation means. Participants will go through 45 scenarios deciding which recipient should receive donations. These preferences will inform the development of an automated fairness-based donation allocation algorithm.
27s

Explanation of donation scenarios
The researcher explains that each scenario presents two recipients, and participants act as the manager deciding who should receive incoming donations. Donations vary by type—from common (bread or produce) to high-demand (meat, dairy, ready-to-eat food).
1m 12s

Details on recipient characteristics
The speaker outlines how recipient organizations differ by size, food access level, and community poverty rates. Organization A serves 100 people monthly with very low food access, while B serves 50 people in a low-access area. Income levels and local poverty rates differ accordingly, with Pittsburgh's median income and poverty rate provided as context.
2m 4s

Additional allocation factors and survey setup
Further details include travel time between donors and recipients, last and total donations received, and donation type distribution. Examples are given comparing A and B in these aspects before beginning the 45-scenario exercise where participants explain their decisions.
3m 13s

Participant's decision rationale during donation exercise
The participant explains their reasoning in choosing between recipients based on poverty rates, income levels, number of donations received, and the commonality of the donations. Decisions show consistent prioritization of recipients with higher poverty and lower income levels.
8m 5s

Reflections on the decision-making process
After completing the survey, the participant notes that it was a positive experience but acknowledges the difficulty of comparing organizations' needs when both experience food insecurity. They confirm the survey reflects real-life factors considered in actual allocation.
23m 52s

Views on fairness and computer-assisted allocation
The participant defines a fair donation decision as one considering organizational need, unmet demands, and efficiency. They express that computers can get close to fair decisions but cannot fully replicate human emotional judgment. Their decision criteria focused on income, poverty, and food access.
25m 46s

Perspectives on donation impact and need measurement
The discussion covers what constitutes a high-impact donation, emphasizing that smaller organizations with fewer alternative sources benefit more. Need is quantified through organizational lists of required items, reflecting specific client needs.
29m 4s

Motivation for participation and perception of volunteering
The participant joined the study after reading about a legal initiative supporting Four One Two Food Rescue. They describe volunteering as rewarding, noting that donation recipients are grateful and that time spent rescuing food feels worthwhile.
31m 26s

Thoughts on improving and aggregating fairness inputs
The participant comments that aggregating diverse stakeholder responses may cause inconsistencies since perspectives differ between volunteers and employees. They suggest that employees of Four One Two should have a stronger influence on final decisions due to their operational insight.
32m 42s

Safety concerns and additional survey factors
The participant identifies building access and safety as real-world factors not reflected in the survey. They describe how volunteers may avoid deliveries to unsecured residential buildings, emphasizing safety risks during donation drop-offs.
35m 14s

Views on demographic information relevance
The participant believes demographic data about recipients is unnecessary for decision-making, trusting Four One Two to make equitable choices. When asked, they reaffirm that decisions should rely more on quantifiable factors like income, poverty, and access rather than age or disability demographics.
36m 1s

Algorithm errors and trust in automation
When discussing algorithmic errors, the participant suggests that such errors could arise if the algorithm allocates differently from human expectations but might still be justified by unseen factors. They express cautious trust in automation, willing to rely on technology once it proves effective and well-tested.
36m 53s

Closing remarks and compensation
The session concludes with the interviewer thanking the participant and confirming their choice of a Starbucks gift card for participation compensation.
39m 22s

Transcript

SPEAKER 1
Has seen significant success in the past two years, but demand has increased beyond their staff capacity. So they are seeking more efficient alternatives. We are partnering with them to build a computer algorithm to automate the donation allocation process. So, like, basically, like, Jennifer England, who's the manager there, I think, she just gets a call about the donation, and then she, in her head, kind of decides who might be a good choice for them. Yeah.

SPEAKER 1
But because now a lot of demand is coming in, we want to help them with an algorithm that could make that process a bit easier. So as part of our research, we're talking to stakeholders like yourselves, so donors, volunteers, recipients, and phones and employees to ask them what fair allocation is because there's no one one right answer when it comes to making a fair offer. To learn what you think is fair, we'll ask you to pick the winning recipient in a series of 45 donation scenarios. And this will take a longer time in the beginning, but we guarantee it will go faster. Once we learn your preferences, we'll aggregate the fairness preference from various stakeholders to design a computer algorithm that can help four one two to make a fair donation application.

SPEAKER 1
So, basically, what you'll be doing today is So there will be scenarios like this. And then basically, for every scenario, you are playing the role of the manager at four one two. So let's say there's a incoming donation. So the incoming donation will always be either a common donation, which could be produce or bread, or it can be a less common and high demand donation, like meat, ready to eat food, or dairy product. Gotcha.

SPEAKER 1
Recipients will vary in their sizes. So in here, a serves 100 people a month. Here, they serve 50 people a month. The clients will also vary in the level of food access. So currently, organization a has extremely low food access, so they can be considered a food desert.

SPEAKER 1
B has low food access, which means they're also in a food desert. Income level is referring to the income level of the area where the clients reside in. So the clients who go to recipient b earn around 20 to 40 k, plus a earns around 0 to 20 k. And the clients in a have a poverty rate of 60

SPEAKER 2
plus percent,

SPEAKER 1
versus b has a poverty rate of 40 to 50%. And as context, Pittsburgh's poverty rate is 23%. On the income level, the median income in Pittsburgh is 41 k. It will also vary in the travel time. So in here, it'll take sixty plus minutes to get to the from the donor to the recipient.

SPEAKER 1
Versus here, it's forty five minute from the donor to the recipient. Last donation refers to when they received their last donation. And then total donation is how many donations they received in the past three months. So in this case, b has five total donations, a about 11 total donations, and then the darker blue are the common donations they have received, and then the lighter blue is the less common donations they have received. And so we will go through 45 of these scenarios.

SPEAKER 1
And after you decide on a or b, it'll be helpful if you could briefly kinda tell us, like, oh, I decided a or b. Yeah. So we can start with this one.

SPEAKER 2
Even though it's low versus extremely low because their poverty rate is higher and their income level is lower. I could be here because it's the less common high demand, and they're gonna serve more people. B, because it's the less common high demand, more people, and their property rates are higher. Bully, I guess b, because they've never received a donation even though their property rates a little bit lower. Guess, a, their donations are about the same apart, same access, but their coffee rates are.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. Probably being because their poverty rate is higher on the A, they're gonna serve more people, same food access, but a higher poverty rate. Since it's a common donation, I'd probably go with a if we have a lower access to food. The same level of access. Even though they have a higher income, they're gonna serve more people, they've never received a donation.

SPEAKER 2
Probably a, because their income levels seem to be less than the poverty rate's higher.

SPEAKER 1
Oh, sorry. A?

SPEAKER 2
I'm sorry.

SPEAKER 1
B. B?

SPEAKER 2
Probably be they have lower income, same poverty rate, but they're gonna serve more people, the less common.

SPEAKER 1
How did you feel about the whole process having to make these decisions? It was good. It was good.

SPEAKER 2
I can see that it'd be difficult, though. Mhmm. Why

SPEAKER 1
do you think it might be difficult for somebody who does this?

SPEAKER 2
Because it's hard to judge one organization's need against another. Mhmm. Because they're both in need of food, and it's a very basic necessity in life.

SPEAKER 1
Do you think this is this survey, what, like, was a good depiction of, like, what happens in reality, or do you think there's, a factor or something that as you, as a volunteer, see that, like, is not included here?

SPEAKER 2
I think it's a pretty good way. Those are definitely factors you would take into account when determining where to make a donation or spend your time at school. Yeah.

SPEAKER 1
Do you think that your opinion on who should get information or not is important or not important?

SPEAKER 2
I mean, I think it's important for a study purpose. Mhmm. It is.

SPEAKER 1
Mhmm. In your opinion, what does a fair, like, donation decision looks like?

SPEAKER 2
Very similar to what you have in the study. It depends on what the need is of the organization, which needs aren't being met, how efficient an organization such as four one two could meet that need, and how far those donations are gonna go towards meeting the needs of the organization providing that food directly to the clients.

SPEAKER 1
Well, one thing that was interesting was, like, you you didn't seem to care about the travel time as much, but, like Really? Which thought as a volunteer, I thought you might care.

SPEAKER 2
Well, I also drive for Lyft.

SPEAKER 1
So Okay.

SPEAKER 2
I like driving. It doesn't bother me. Who

SPEAKER 1
do you think decides who is more needy or deserving?

SPEAKER 2
Say that again?

SPEAKER 1
Who do you think decides who is more needy or deserving?

SPEAKER 2
Oh, like, an organization?

SPEAKER 1
I'll just, like, generally if some if somebody had to make a decision about these things

SPEAKER 2
I am a statistics type person, so I wanna look at numbers and see, like, what you have there Mhmm. The poverty rates, the income level, what their level of access to the food is, and then try and get a Okay. I guess you could try to score organ like, organizations or groups of individuals and determine what the score of need is based upon those factors. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
Do you think a computer can make a fair decision?

SPEAKER 2
I think it can get close. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
What do you exactly mean by Close.

SPEAKER 2
I definitely think, like, with AI and stuff like that, there there's going to be some human element, some level of emotion Mhmm. That humans would put into a fair assessment that a computer is not just not going to be able to fully grasp.

SPEAKER 1
During the survey, what factors do you think you prioritize the most?

SPEAKER 2
Definitely the income level versus their poverty Mhmm. And their access to the family.

SPEAKER 1
Why do you think you prioritize those $400 a month?

SPEAKER 2
Because I think it's important to not only look at the income, but see what that poverty rate is in relation to the income. There were some instances where they could be making a 100,000, which is way above, like, the Pittsburgh poverty level, but their poverty level within that could have been 60%. Yeah. So Okay.

SPEAKER 1
When you think about, like, a donation that goes to somewhere, what would be, like, a high impact donation?

SPEAKER 2
Like, what types of food?

SPEAKER 1
Like, let's say there was a decision that had to be made from a between AMB. Like, if you wanted to make, like, a high impact donation, what would that look like? High

SPEAKER 2
impact, I would say, you have to take into account the two organizations that you have and what they need. Because if there's a large organization, they get donations from multiple different places, and they have less of a regular need, and there's a smaller organization that doesn't have access to those other partner organizations. The four one two food rescue to the smaller organization may make a bigger impact to them. Get them closer to serving a 100% of their clients' needs.

SPEAKER 1
How would you quantify a need?

SPEAKER 2
Well, usually organizations have a list of the types of baked goods, spreads, produce, shower things. Like, they have a list of the things that they need for their clients Mhmm. That they put together for their clients either on a weekly, monthly basis. Mhmm. So I would say that would be the need.

SPEAKER 2
I see.

SPEAKER 1
Is this something you thought about? How for one to make their decisions?

SPEAKER 2
Actually, I have. Yeah.

SPEAKER 1
Was what was the thought process? Like, usually, what was it like about?

SPEAKER 2
I don't know. I just kinda thought they either reached out to companies or companies reached out to them that were interested in making donations. And then I guess there would be someone who is just trying to see where that donation can go to based on maybe a list of organizations that have requested to partner with four one two.

SPEAKER 1
What motivated you to participate in the series then?

SPEAKER 2
There was actually an article in Allegheny County Bar Association's lawyers magazine on the attorneys against hunger partnering with four one two.

SPEAKER 1
Oh, wow. Do you feel like your time is used well after doing a rescue? After it? Yeah. Or when you do a rescue, do you feel like your time is well spent?

SPEAKER 2
I I think so. Mhmm. At least with my regular rescue, all the residents of the building are extremely grateful. They're looking forward to that donation every week, so it's definitely time well spent. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
After having done the survey, do you think there are maybe better ways that we can make donations? Is there something that you had in mind that, like, maybe this way we can make prayer donations or decisions?

SPEAKER 2
I can't think of one. Okay.

SPEAKER 1
So while we're going to do with all the responses from, like, volunteers, recipients, donors, and everyone, we're going to aggregate it to make a offer them. Mhmm. Do you think the aggregation of responses is fair? Like, will be unfair? I

SPEAKER 2
think there could be issues because, like, the volunteers not every volunteer Mhmm. Likes driving as much as me, so they may take that into consideration more, which isn't wrong. Mhmm. But that's gonna be a factor that maybe volunteers are gonna consider more heavily than maybe the employees of four one two because they don't necessarily see a drive time as a reason not to make the donation. They see it as this organization needs this, and we wanna give it to them.

SPEAKER 2
So I think there may be some issues in aggregating Mhmm.
The responses.

SPEAKER 1
Do you think, like, one stakeholder should have a stronger voice than the other?

SPEAKER 2
Say that again?

SPEAKER 1
Do you think one of these stakeholders should have a stronger voice? Or if you think so, which stakeholder do you So either employees are foreign to, donors, volunteers, and recipients.

SPEAKER 2
I don't think donors are going to be impacted necessarily on where their donation is going. Mhmm. Because they're most likely more interested in just giving that donation, not necessarily where it goes. Mhmm. So I think it's between, like, the employees of four one two and the drivers, the volunteers.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. And I'd say more heavily rely upon the employees. I know it's driver based Mhmm. The whole organization getting the food to and from. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
So you do have to take into consideration the drivers and make sure that the drive time probably isn't an hour Mhmm. Or more for most drives. But I think, ultimately, the employees will be more heavily. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
Could you think of any factors having visited some recipients that could be included that you don't see in the survey?

SPEAKER 2
I don't know about any factors for the survey purposes, but I know something that can dissuade volunteers from taking donation is being dropped off. If it is a building, like just a residential building with no front desk, it could potentially be a safety issue for going in to an apartment building when there's nobody there to greet you. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
Some stakeholders mentioned that they would like to know the demographic that the recipient serves. Do you think that's important to you or no?

SPEAKER 2
I don't think that's important to me. I guess I sort of just trust four one two that they're making the best decision possible Mhmm. For getting these food donations that would just be waste to people who need access to food. If

SPEAKER 1
you let's say you have to make you you are the one making a decision. Mhmm. Do you think that the vaccine will matter or not really? Like, whether they serve elderly or children or disabled?

SPEAKER 2
Doesn't matter to me. It's really just comes down to numbers Mhmm. And that income versus poverty versus access to food. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
If if our algorithm made an error, what do you think an error made by the algorithm looks like?

SPEAKER 2
Like an error in, like, sending it to b versus a?

SPEAKER 1
Maybe, like, you maybe you made a decision, and then you look at it and it's like, oh, I think that's an error. What would that look like?

SPEAKER 2
Like, in the code?

SPEAKER 1
Not really in the code, but, like, let's say, there was a donation that came in, and then the hour that made a decision, but you weren't happy with it.

SPEAKER 2
As a volunteer? Or no. No.

SPEAKER 1
In this case, you're the the decision maker.

SPEAKER 2
Okay. So I'm the employee, and I think it should've gone to a. Mhmm. But the algorithm said it'd be fair if it goes to b. Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
Well, then I guess it wouldn't be an error if we trust the algorithm. Mhmm. Maybe the algorithm's taking into consideration something that we're just not taking into consideration in a human brain. I don't know. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
What's your, like, general trust level or thoughts about an automated system?

SPEAKER 2
I'm slowly starting to be okay with, like, automated things. Mhmm. I usually don't buy it first. Mhmm. Let everybody see how it works.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. Get all the kinks out. Mhmm. But, I mean, if it if something has, like, good reviews and it's automated, then I'll trust it.

SPEAKER 1
What would, like, a good review of an algorithm

SPEAKER 2
look like

SPEAKER 1
as a security?

SPEAKER 2
Well, I don't know. Like, I bought the Vi, I don't know if you heard, the Vi head phones. So it's like an AI Mhmm. Personal trainer in your headphones, and it learns your fitness goals and how often like, what your goals are, and then it'll set up a program. So I guess I don't know.

SPEAKER 1
Oh, like I see. So, like, after you see the decisions, if you're kinda happy with

SPEAKER 2
it Yeah.

SPEAKER 1
I see. I see. Think that was good. Okay. Yeah.

SPEAKER 1
Thank you for taking your time today. Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
No problem.

SPEAKER 1
Do you prefer Amazon or a Starbucks gift card for Xfinity?

SPEAKER 2
I'll do Starbucks.

SPEAKER 1
Starbucks? Okay. Can we just get a signature? Yeah. And I'll send the coupon over after I see it.

SPEAKER 1
Okay. Yeah. Thank you.

VOMO: Transcribe Audio to Text
AI Meeting Notes Taker
https://web.vomo.ai/